
Paper 1, Option 1E: Russia, 1917–91: from Lenin to Yeltsin

Overview

This option comprises a study in breadth, in which students will learn about the key political, social and economic features of communist rule in Russia during the twentieth century, an era that saw its authority and influence rise to the status of a superpower, only to diminish and decline later in the century.

The focus of study is on developments and changes over a broad timescale, and so the content is presented as themes spanning a significant duration: 1917–85. This option also contains a study in depth of historical interpretations on a broad question, which is contextualised by, and runs on from, the themes: reasons for the fall of the USSR, c1985–91.

Themes	Content
1 Communist government in the USSR, 1917–85	• Establishing Communist Party control, 1917–24: the creation of a one-party state and the party congress of 1921; the nature of government under Lenin; the growing centralisation of power. • Stalin in power, 1928–53: the elimination of opponents in government and party; the purges of the 1930s; Stalin's power over party and state. • Government, 1953–85: changes in leaders' control of the state across the period; Khrushchev's attempts to reform government including de-Stalinisation; the return to stability under Brezhnev, 1964–82; growing political stagnation, 1982–85.
2 Industrial and agricultural change, 1917–85	• Towards a command economy, 1917–28: the nationalisation of industry; War Communism and the New Economic Policy; state control of industry and agriculture. • Industry and agriculture in the Stalin era: the Five-Year Plans and industrial change; agricultural collectivisation and its impact; recovery from war after 1945. • Changes in industry and agriculture, 1953–85, including: the promotion of light industry, chemicals and consumer goods; investment in agriculture and the Virgin Lands Scheme; the limited attempts at reform after 1964; economic decline.

Themes	Content
3 Control of the people, 1917–85	- Media, propaganda and religion: state control of mass media and propaganda; attacks on religious beliefs and practices. The personality cults of Stalin, Khrushchev and Brezhnev. - The secret police: attacks on opponents of the government; the roles of Yagoda, Yezhov and Beria; Andropov's suppression of dissidents, 1967–82; the continued monitoring of popular discontent, 1982–85. - The state and cultural change: <i>Proletkult</i>, <i>avant-garde</i> and Socialist Realism, 1917–53; nonconformity from the 1950s; clashes between artists and the government to 1985.
4 Social developments, 1917–85	- Social security: full employment, housing and social benefits, 1917–53. Khrushchev, Brezhnev and the promotion of a stable society, 1953–85. - Women and the family: the changing status of different groups of women in towns and countryside; changing government attitudes towards the family as a social unit. - Education and young people: the growth of primary, secondary and higher education; the reduction of illiteracy; state control of the curriculum.

Historical interpretations	Content
What explains the fall of the USSR, c1985–91?	- The significance of the economic weaknesses of the USSR and the failure of reform. - The effects of Gorbachev's failure to reform the Communist Party and the Soviet government. - The impact of the nationalist resurgence in the late 1980s in the Soviet republics and in the communist states of Eastern Europe. - How far Gorbachev and Yeltsin can be seen as responsible for the collapse of the USSR in 1991.